

Hit 'em where it hurts
Naval commanders at the start of World War II were generally complacent about the threat from submarines. By the time this US Submarine Service poster was designed in 1943, however, submarines had more than proved their worth.

abandoned adherence to the Washington Treaty. The rise to power of Adolf Hitler in Germany in 1933 was inevitably followed by German naval rearmament, which Britain tried to control by agreeing to accept construction of a German fleet a third of the size of its own.

DESCENT INTO WAR

Facing the possibility of having to take on Germany, Japan, and Italy simultaneously, with only France as an ally, Britain was acutely aware that the Royal Navy was no longer adequate to the challenge it might confront. Fortunately for the British, Nazi Germany was only in the early stages of naval expansion when war broke out in 1939. The United States, which had become accustomed to view Japan as its major potential rival at sea, committed itself in 1940 to the creation of a "Two Ocean Navy"—capable of fighting simultaneously against the Japanese in the Pacific and Nazi Germany in the Atlantic. But the expansion of the US Navy was barely under way when the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor brought America fully into the war at the end of 1941, its destroyers having already begun contributing to Atlantic convoy defense.

TRANSITIONAL TECHNOLOGY

World War II started at an uncertain transitional moment in the evolution of naval technology and tactics. Submarines had proved their effectiveness in World War I, yet they remained in practice only "submersibles"—craft that could dive but had to spend most of their time on the surface. Even in Germany, there was a reluctance to accord the U-boats top priority, and naval commanders used to focusing on surface warships were often complacent about their ability to cope with the underwater threat. Aircraft meanwhile, although appreciated, were underrated. The United States and Japan had experimented in exercises with the aggressive use of aircraft carriers as a prime strike force capable of crippling an enemy fleet at long range. But there was still a tendency even in those air-conscious fleets to revert to regarding carriers as ancillary to the battleships and cruisers, simply providing reconnaissance or air defence for the big-gun battlewagons. Japanese naval aviation was the most advanced in the world, yet at the end of the 1930s Japan devoted vast resources to building the largest battleships ever seen, the ill-fated Yamato class. A vision of decisive battles between surface fleets with their great guns continued to dominate naval thinking.

In the event, World War II did involve a good number of battles in which exchange of gunfire between large surface warships was crucial, or even the sole action, and in most engagements it played at least a part. But the overwhelming importance of naval air power was clear from start to finish of the conflict.

Sweetheart of the Marianas
Naval air power proved decisive in World War II—the F-4U Corsair fighter-bomber was nicknamed the "sweetheart of the Marianas" by US ground forces for its role in the conquest of the Pacific Islands.







